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Plas Johnson

Millions of television and movie viewers have heard the distinctive sound of Plas Johnson's tenor sax. When Henry Mancini needed the perfect sound to bring his "Pink Panther" theme alive he knew who to call. Plas has played on countless movie, TV, pop and R & B recordings, as well as being part of the west coast jazz scene. He came from a musical family, and grew up in the birthplace of jazz, New Orleans.

Plas Johnson was interviewed by Monk Rowe at the Sarasota Jazz Festival on April 12, 1996.

MR: Today we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Sarasota Florida. My name is Monk Rowe and it's a thrill for me to have Plas Johnson with us today, saxophonist extrordinaire. I think I can use that word. Have you ever stopped to try to figure out how many recordings you've been on?

PJ: No.

MR: It'd be hard, wouldn't it?

PJ: It would be very difficult.

MR: Because you've been a leader and a studio man, and in big bands. How did all that get started?

PJ: Rock & roll. Rock & roll in the 50s. I played on a lot of the rhythm & blues labels when I first came to L.A. in '55 — '54, '55. and that music was taken over by the rock 'n rollers. And they I guess they were pop artists, trying to duplicate this music that was so hot with I guess the white teenage buying public at the time.

MR: When you got to L.A. and you maybe — how do you get your first date when you get to a big city and you are an unknown?

PJ: You don't. Unless you're playing with somebody who is going to make a recording. I've played around town. My brother and I got into L.A. around 1954, and you know we were half a band, he is a piano player and I'm a sax player so all you really have to do is find a drummer, and if it's a real good gig we had a bass player.

MR: Yeah. Could afford a fourth.

PJ: But we starved around quite a few months before getting on to something. And I met and played with Johnny Otis. Johnny Otis had his going Rhythm & Blues Revue going at the time, and I played with him a while, and I started getting calls for some rhythm & blues dates. I'm trying to remember the labels now, Modern, Aladdin — and these artists, well actually one of the artists that recorded on these labels was Charles Brown, who I first went on the road with when I was 19 years old, out in New Orleans. It was my bus ticket out of New York was the Charles Brown Band. So you get to know people in the town, when you get to the town, you go around and try to make all the jam sessions and people

hear you play and usually people like my playing when I play. And Johnny Otis did some records on Capitol and I had heard at Capitol via Dave Cavanaugh, who was a producer and A&R man out there, and he got me on fabulous recordings with Nat Cole and Frank Sinatra and Peggy Lee and Ella Mae Morse. I forget all the people. Capitol was a hot label at the time.

MR: Yeah, he did some good work with Nancy Wilson.

PJ: Yeah. But that was later.

MR: Were you from a musical family?

PJ: Yeah. My father played banjo in the early days and saxophone later. He was a senior, I'm a junior. And my mother, whose name was Grace, she was an entertainer, played piano and sang. And she had a fantastic talent. Never read music or anything but she had real good talent and could play anything that she heard. And my sister sang, my brother sang and played the piano. So we got into music quite early, in fact we were I guess four, five and six or something like this, we used to do three part harmonies to the popular tunes of the time.

MR: Good ear training.

PJ: Yeah.

MR: Did you start out on the tenor sax or —

PJ: No I started out on soprano, because my father just came home from a pawn shop one day and he brought a soprano home, he had picked it up quite cheaply, so I started playing that when I was twelve. And we had an alto later and I don't know, a year later something like that, and I don't think I got my tenor until I was about fifteen.

MR: What kind of music was popular on the radio when you were forming your musical—

PJ: In New Orleans it was Dixieland music and blues music. Great blues music. I'll say blues music it included artists like Dinah Washington, you know she sang blues but you know she was just a great singer. And I heard Louis Jordan and well all blues artists, T-Bone Walker, B.B. King. My father was an Ellington fan so we had some Ellington records and he was also a Johnny Hodges fan, he was an alto player so his great thrill in life would have been to play like Johnny Hodges, which of course he couldn't do.

MR: Not many people could. Yeah, he had a sound. How about saxophone players that caught your attention in the beginning?

PJ: In the beginning? The blues players. Louis Jordan, hard swinging blues player. Later on in the middle '40s I guess I heard some of the bebop players or players that were on the bebop label like Don Byas and that. Let's see, Gene Ammons was popular on the radio too. So it was kind of a combination of all kinds of music and you know, D.J.s in those days they got to, some of them got to select what they wanted to play instead of maybe like today where a program director does that and the D.J. just makes conversation

between the takes a lot of times. I think very few D.J.s now get to select their own programming.

MR: Yeah. Jimmy Witherspoon was talking about that earlier, about how important the D.J.s were. Each city had its own kind of personality.

PJ: Right. So they played what they liked and if a D.J., he would get a following by what he played, if people liked what he played then they would tune in to his program.

MR: And a lot of them were playing black music that the white teenager started to like. Is that correct?

PJ: Sure. The blues artists were like Charles Brown, Amos Millburn, Roy Milton, some of the singing groups — Clyde McPhatter and the Drifters, they had an upbeat type of Gospel quartet. And they were quite popular in the black community also.

MR: When you got to L.A. then you started playing on rhythm & blues and — was it rock & roll yet? Was it called rock & roll?

PJ: Well I didn't start playing rhythm & blues, I started playing anywhere I could get a job, but actually one of my first jobs really was a jazz job, kind of a jazz job in the city of Long Beach, with a drummer called George Jenkins, who was Dinah Washington's first husband, and played with Lionel Hampton and he was a great drummer. Let's see, me, George, Wesley Prince and my brother on piano, we played in a joint out in Long Beach which was kind of a sailor town with bars and music six nights a week. And stayed there. We stayed there for about six months. So that was our first big job where we had a steady job. Before that we were doing jam sessions for three dollars. Five dollars.

MR: I guess they call that scuffling, huh?

PJ: Scuffling.

MR: Paying your dues, all those things. Sounds like you have to do it I guess. I'm going to test your memory now, can you tell me some of the first solos that you did on some of these recordings that went on to sell some records?

PJ: Oh, no. There was many, but I don't know. I don't have any idea which was first. There was a period where the white artists were kind of covering these rhythm & blues records that were coming out and if they made any kind of radio noise and you could tell it was going to be a hit, well they would cover it maybe with their own artists and superior distribution and everything and just take the hit away.

MR: Like Pat Boone.

PJ: Yeah, Pat Boone started doing a Fats Domino thing. Well that's taking the hit one step higher, because I'm sure he could sell so many more records on that. And young Ricky Nelson, I played on his stuff, and he did some Fats Domino, "I'm Walking."

MR: When you would do these things, the recording at that time, were they done in parts or did everybody play together?

PJ: Oh, yeah, they were done like mono — mono track. Stereo hadn't come out yet, and everybody that was going to be on the record was in the studio.

MR: What a novel idea.

PJ: Yeah, right. How to make a record.

MR: Did you know ahead of time what you were getting into when you got to a particular date?

PJ: No, most times we didn't.

MR: Yeah. You'd just go and listen to the tune basically and find your part. Did the producers often have an idea of what they wanted you to do?

PJ: Yeah, usually. Either the producer or the artist. Like we played behind artists, like Bobby Day or Larry Williams who did "Bony Maronie"; Bobby Day did "Rockin' Robin" and what else — they did pretty well. And artists like that had a whole concept of what they wanted the band to do and we did it. They would sing riffs and stuff to us and show us how the song goes and everything. And it usually came together in three hours.

MR: Was there a time when you were driving in your car — did you have a car?

PJ: Yeah I had a car. You can't survive in L.A. without a car.

MR: Okay. Was there a time when you were driving and that song came on the radio that you heard yourself for the first time.

PJ: Oh yes. That's always a thrill yes.

MR: I guess. "Turn that up."

PJ: And my brother and I had recorded in New Orleans but we did our own thing and I played behind a couple of artists there too. But hadn't gotten to any serious recording for a living until I got to L.A. and had been there about a year and a half.

MR: Tell us about studio work for film.

PJ: Well I had no plans of becoming a studio player it just kind of happened. The blues part of my playing got me on a lot of record dates, and my playing wasn't all blues, you know I could play a pretty good ballad and follow changes and stuff like that and had a pretty good sound and I think one of the first arrangers to use me in that capacity, you know other than the blues stuff, was Les Baxter and maybe Van Alexander, Billy May, Nelson Riddle. I was being discovered by arrangers who used me in a solo capacity. Many times I'd go to a date and just play the solo and somebody else played the chart. It was kind of fun times.

MR: Every day something different?

PJ: Yeah. Kind of just from '56 on it kind of just mushroomed and I was quite busy between '56 and '62 or 3, up until the time maybe when the Beatles music came in and pop music changed entirely. But I was still busy because I did T.V. and movie stuff.

MR: What was the big band experience? Where did that fit in as far as your career? Was it in the '60s?

PJ: Mostly in the studios because I hadn't had any big band experience outside the studios at that time. And so the big band writers like Shorty Rodgers, Henry Mancini, Van Alexander, Billy May. Ernie Freeman did some big band stuff and he was also on some of the rock & roll stuff so actually he was really a classic writer, a very good arranger and stuff, but we played in a jazz trio also for about a year where he played Hammond organ.

MR: Has the— I don't want to say legal end of it — has the financial end of it changed for studio musicians at all from the late '50s until now? For instance if you play on a tune and it sells a lot of records —

PJ: You have no rights outside of union scale, unless you make some kind of artist's deal.

MR: Which is unlikely.

PJ: It's unlikely if you could call it — as a side man. Very unlikely, unless you're the author of the tune or the music.

MR: Well you happened to play on a couple of things where you could be one of the most heard saxophonists around — tell us about how Henry Mancini started to use you.

PJ: I had worked at Universal and had played on — Henry Mancini was kind of a junior writer out there at that time. So I played on several things with him before that. I'd also played on his "Peter Gunn." And I had recorded "Peter Gunn" — I can't think of the trumpet player's name — but I'd recorded "Peter Gunn" on another record and it turned out to be a million seller. And this was —

MR: I didn't know that was you on "Peter Gunn."

PJ: This was instead of Henry Mancini's recording. I'll think of the trumpet player's name in a minute. So we had crossed paths before. And Henry had the talent of matching the player with the tune you know. He would call just the right saxophone player for what he was writing on. Just the right harmonica player, or, you know, he knew players quite well and he knew music. He had a knack for putting stuff together that matched, and I guess that's how I came to work on his "Pink Panther."

MR: It's a classic I think you could say. Certainly had a sound to it. Did you have any idea at the time that it was going to become such a — one of those tunes that everybody can whistle.

PJ: No. Of course not. But we did have an idea at the time that it was a great piece of music because it was like eight o'clock on a cold winter morning and I forget how many, it was a full orchestra with strings and everything, and after the tune was recorded, after the performance of the tune the orchestra applauded.

MR: A good premonition.

PJ: They liked it.

MR: I have had students that just had to play that you know. They really want to get that sax lick down the way you did it. It's kind of hard. Tell me about the Rod Stewart thing, how that came about.

PJ: I was just called. I've read recently that with the advent of multi-track, producers many times would call several soloists to play the same solo. And so I found out recently that that may not be my solo on Rod Stewart's record.

MR: Really?

PJ: A saxophonist by the name of Jerry Jumonville also was called in and Jerry is not a student of mine but he's been a fan of mine for years, and we talk about pieces and he likes my style, and so actually when I heard the solo I really thought it was me, but I don't think so because I've seen on Jerry's record he put that he played it so it just might be his solo.

MR: Well if it's not you it's somebody trying to be you.

PJ: Well exactly. But I was called and I did play. So who knows what comes out of it? And that happens many times.

MR: Or sometimes it could be half you—

PJ: Well that's another thing that happens where you play a twelve-bar solo and you might have four bars from track seven and the last two bars from track fifteen and somewhere in the middle from another track. And it can be done electronically so that it sounds like one solo. In fact I've had it done to my own solos. And I liked it.

MR: I guess if the producer has got good taste and good ears you know.

PJ: Exactly.

MR: What's been your involvement in any jazz education things? You mentioned you were working on a book.

PJ: Oh yeah, well I've been working on a book for ten years.

MR: It better be good when it comes out.

PJ: I'm still putting it out of the computer a page at a time but I've got a deadline now and I think I'll finally have it all out of the computer this month, and then there's a struggle now to get it published. You asked me to send you a copy so I will. See what you think.

MR: We'll give it a try, yeah.

PJ: In fact I'll show you some of it today.

MR: Good.

PJ: I have some pages with me. But it's been kind of a fun thing. I started teaching an improv class oh about five or six years ago. And it was really my first experience with teaching, with trying to impart to players what I do. Because I had no other teaching experience, I guess why I was there was to play for them and to kind of tell them what I do. And that's

a whole different way of thinking because most players don't think about what they do, they just do it.

MR: Yeah. It's hard to talk about it.

PJ: Yeah. Like I've had a student say — when I say student, I don't mean kids I mean players who are already developed because I don't teach scales and stuff like that — he said, "Well what do you do with your mouth you know when you hit so and so?" And I had to think about it and I had to play it over again and then I said, "well the mouthpiece should be a little further up on your tongue."

MR: Right.

PJ: It's a revelation to me, but that's not what the book is, the book is about licks. I'm self taught and when I think back over it my first experience with playing when I didn't know how to play or what to play was listening to other players play and copying, copying what they play or trying to mimic what they play. And it does turn out to be licks, like a study of blues playing, it's like licks. You can't say well it's just three chord changes. You know better. It's licks, a little two-bar, one-bar, four-bar phrases that you can intertwine in different ways. And if you are a practicing player then you get to try out things that you think work. And if not then you should practice them. You should collect them and practice them. And the more licks you have in your pockets, you know major ninth licks, major seven licks, 2-5 licks, 2-5-1 licks, 3-6, 3-6-2-5. And actually these are little melodies that fit over those chord changes. And you know when young players are coming up to play and they know their harmony on the instrument and everything, well the next step is how do you apply it? So you see the chord changes. They say well I have the chord changes, but you know, what do you play, what do you play when you see such-and-such chord changes. And knowing the licks that fit over these chord changes will help you put some kind of a solo together. And the next alternative is to take the tune and listen to a developed player, what he does on that tune, and study it, and learn it, note for note. And when I talk to players, like Ricky, you know Ricky is a player that came up the same way and we were talking about that last night. He just studied players. When you're learning to play you study players who you want to sound like and who you think swings pretty good. And your style is how you interpret what you pick up from the players and how you put it together.

MR: Usually there's one or two people that will speak to you I think, you know?

PJ: But the more the merrier. Because there's a lot of great players. You know you've got, my biggest complaint out there is young players they exclude so many of the great players of the past and if you're playing tenor saxophone he should hear Ben Webster or Illinois Jacquet, Lester Young, Don Byas, Gene Ammons. None of these players should be excluded from your listening habits.

MR: You were part of the Jauggernaut?

PJ: Yeah I was with the first band, yeah. Richie Kamuca was the other tenor and mostly the same players that he has right now. Marshall Royal was first alto. Buster Cooper, Benny Powell. It was fun playing.

MR: It's a good line up.

PJ: And you know, music is eternal.

MR: Did you ever have occasion to play behind Joe Williams and some of the other singers?

PJ: Yeah, I went to France with Joe Williams, I forget how long ago, oh, five years ago, where he took a small group, two horns and a rhythm section to do a festival in southern France. I've played with Joe many times. But not for long periods of time or anything like that, just like being on the same venue.

MR: What's in the future for you right now?

PJ: Well I think I want to play more. I want to get out of the studio. But I still love to do studio work and I still get called for certain kinds of work like really what I first started getting calls for, and that's blues solos, rockin' stuff from the '40s, sometimes just beautiful music, I just did a couple of Latin albums with a young producer. Latin music, and four horns, two-three Latin rhythm section, and that was fun.

MR: And this evening you're playing in the Prez Conference? Oh, no, you're playing with Jay tonight.

PJ: I'm playing with Jay.

MR: And what's it like playing with a violin? With Claude?

PJ: Oh I love it he plays great blues, actually plays good jazz. And we played together before — well we didn't play together before, I met him in L.A. and took him around to a couple of clubs to set in, that was the first time I'd heard him. I didn't know anything about him. But he's remarkable. How old is he?

MR: He is 91 I think? I think he's pretty old. I can look. Yeah. And he is a great guy and he knows a lot of history.

PJ: Oh you've interviewed him?

MR: Yes. And he was Basie's first guitar player.

PJ: Yeah he must have great recall too because I've talked with him and he knows a lot of jazz history.

MR: Well Jay gave you quite a compliment while you were in the other room, he said, "Plas can play anything, anything you throw at him."

PJ: Well I don't know. I've had my ups and downs.

MR: Are you able to be, with the studio work, be choosy if you want to be?

PJ: Well you are always able to be choosy, the other question is can you make a living being choosy. Not very much. You have to be quite in demand and maybe in demand for some

kind of music that is popular. But no, you more or less have to be available. I was trying to play all the doubles and like the clarinet and the bass clarinet and the bass flute and the piccolo and the alto flute. I have them all. But you have to, more or less to make a good living in the studio you have to make an effort to play anything that comes along. But I want to play more live. I like doing things like we did last night. I like to play schools, bring some big band charts along and teach the sax section how to play. I've done — I don't do much of that but I'd like to do more of that. Get a good collection of some big band charts that I like to play.

MR: Do you have a core of folks in L.A. you like to work with on a club date if you can?

PJ: Yeah I had a four-piece group that I worked with for oh a couple of years. In fact they're on my album, they're "Hot, Blue and Sexy." Cedric Lawson is the piano player that used to play with Miles, Richard Reed, the bass player, and Richard Simon sometimes, a bass player. Wonderful bass player. They both are. And on drums I had my old buddy from the '50's jazz in the clubs, Johnny Kirkwood. And he's been around. He can play a good shuffle and a back beat. Plays fairly good jazz too. But he's my age. You get a different take from the younger players. I have some young drummers that I like too, but it's interesting. You don't really get to — get into that much unless you work a lot around town which I don't do anymore.

MR: Well it's been a real pleasure talking to you, and I hope that your gig with Jay is a hoot.

PJ: It should be fun. There's always a few surprises in store.

MR: I know. These festivals are kind of interesting because the music is almost always superlative you know but every once in a while you see people looking like what are we supposed to do here?

PJ: Is this train going to derail before the last chorus or what?

MR: But it's been so wonderful to be able to just stand back stage and watch you gentlemen as each person arrives and some you haven't seen each other in years and I just really like watching that. There seems to be such a fraternity.

PJ: Well that's the nice thing about these kind of things because you know as a saxophone player myself I'm not likely to run into the other saxophone players and I know and like unless it's a festival or one of these kind of things that brings many musicians and many bands together. So that part of it is very rewarding. I want to do more of these.

MR: All right. Well on behalf of Hamilton College, I want to thank you for joining us, and have a good gig.

PJ: Well it's my pleasure. Thank you for having me.